

Chapter 175-1

The mountaintop.

The dim yellow setting sun had completely disappeared behind the mountain. The verdant hills held a few traces of spring vitality. Huichang Temple's incense was flourishing, and visitors still came and went in an endless stream, though most were heading down the mountain.

The entrance to the three thousand steps was desolate and deserted compared to the cable car entrance.

Dusk closed in on all sides. The lights of the entire city lit up in an instant. Scattered points of light dotted the base of the mountain, and with a casual glance, one could see the tallest building in the city.

Shen Siyan stood firmly behind Shen Hui, while Shen Hui stood with her back to the streetlamp, hands in her pockets, her silhouette lonely and desolate.

Before long, Shen Hui walked toward the three thousand steps.

"Second Sister." Shen Siyan called out from behind her. "Where are you going?"

Shen Hui didn't even turn her head: "To atone."

Shen Hui walked down with unwavering determination, her white sneakers quickly becoming covered in dust.

Shen Siyan didn't dare to pass her, and even less did he dare to stop her. He could only silently follow behind.

There were only the two of them on this path. They could hear the sound of wind blowing through the treetops—lively yet lonely.

Perhaps all paths in this world are the same—difficult and rough.

But there are thousands upon thousands of ways to walk them.

Shen Hui didn't know what kind of feelings she was walking down the three thousand steps with. She only knew that each step she took was heavy.

She didn't know how long she walked. In any case, several streetlamps around them had broken down, leaving the path too dark to see.

Shen Siyan turned on his flashlight behind her, illuminating the path ahead.

It wasn't until she heard the sound of knees hitting the ground, and the sound of a head heavily striking the stone steps, that she stopped.

She and Zhao Xuning were separated by more than a dozen stone steps. But Zhao Xuning seemed not to see her, only focusing on the next step ahead.

Zhao Xuning's expression was cold as always. Her whole body was dirty. She had already bundled up her white coat and tossed it to Liang Shi beside her. Two buttons of her white shirt were undone, and her sleeves were rolled up. Her complexion was pale, large beads of sweat dripping from her forehead, her lips without a trace of color.

This was probably the first time Shen Hui had seen such a wretched Zhao Xuning.

Far from the one in her memory.

Even back when she had a car accident and miscarriage, Zhao Xuning had only gotten red eyes at her bedside.

Later, when arguing with her sister at the hospital, she had only shouted hoarsely a few times.

She had never imagined she would one day see Zhao Xuning like this.

It was originally just words spoken in anger. Years of accumulated resentment had burst out when she came running over.

But she never expected that Zhao Xuning would actually do it.

She said she would kneel her way up the three thousand steps, and so it was one step, one bow—not a single step could be faked.

This was Zhao Xuning.

The resilient Zhao Xuning.

Shen Hui stood in place, her vision blurring. Shen Siyan handed her a tissue, but Shen Hui instinctively turned away, raising her hand to wipe away her tears. "Got sand in my eyes."

But there was no wind now.

The spring breeze had understood the mood and stopped blowing.

Adding warmth to this cold night.

But even without the spring breeze, what was meant to be chaotic would still be chaotic.

Such as one's heart and mind.

Shen Hui closed her eyes briefly, then walked toward Zhao Xuning with firm steps. Just as Zhao Xuning was about to kneel, she reached out and caught her, her slender body supporting all of Zhao Xuning's weight.

Zhao Xuning looked up. Seeing it was her, she smiled lightly, but the movement of her lips made her gasp in pain.

Zhao Xuning's voice was hoarse: "Why did you come?"

"Do you still want to continue up?" Shen Hui asked.

Zhao Xuning nodded: "I promised you."

"You can break the promise," Shen Hui said. "I'm not getting engaged anymore."

Zhao Xuning stared at her for a while and smiled lightly. "Why are you crying again?"

Shen Hui opened her mouth but didn't know what to say for a moment.

Zhao Xuning took out a handkerchief from her shirt pocket and handed it to her: "My hands are dirty. Wipe it yourself."

Shen Hui exhaled softly: "Didn't you say you'd rather die than kneel up the three thousand steps?"

"People can change." Zhao Xuning raised her hand to check her watch. "Already at one thousand seven hundred and eighty-nine. Still nine hundred and ninety-nine to go."

As she spoke, she turned her face and started coughing, coughing until her face turned red—which actually added some color to it.

Liang Shi immediately handed over water.

There were two gray marks at Zhao Xuning's knees, looking like they were about to wear through.

"Then have you changed?" Shen Hui asked.

Zhao Xuning nodded: "Mm."

She looked up at the path ahead, unable to see the end.

Shen Hui said: "You've achieved your goal. You don't need to kneel anymore."

"Going soft again." Zhao Xuning said with a smile, her tone intimate. "Didn't you say you were going to get revenge on me?"

Shen Hui pressed her lips together: "I've already gotten my revenge."

"But I haven't reached the top yet." Zhao Xuning smiled. "If I promised you, I have to do it."

Shen Hui's voice choked: "Are there few things you promised me but didn't do?"

"Which ones?" Zhao Xuning asked back.

"Junior year, you said we would go watch the sunrise together." Shen Hui sniffled and really did recount them one by one.

"Senior year, you said you would help me lose weight down to a hundred jin.¹ That same year, you promised to fold a thousand paper cranes for me. The first year abroad, you said you would knit me a scarf..." Shen Hui looked at her. "Should I continue?"

"Mm?" Zhao Xuning lightly licked her cracked lips.

Shen Hui gently closed her eyes, tears falling: "The last one—you said you would walk with me to the end and never break up."

"So, I'm still working on it." Zhao Xuning still smiled lightly, her eyes reddened. "The day we were supposed to watch the sunrise, you were on your period. Your stomach hurt so much you didn't fall asleep until two. I didn't wake you."

"You clearly loved eating so much. I just wanted to see you do what you love, so I kept buying you food. But I was the one who lost weight."

"The paper cranes I folded—you hugged them like a trash can and threw up on them when you were drunk. They were all ruined and thrown in the garbage."

"The scarf I knitted for you... was too ugly. I put it at the bottom of the closet. You didn't take it when you went abroad, and you never saw it."

Zhao Xuning spoke weakly, but still forced herself to continue.

She looked up at Shen Hui and blinked. "A-Hui, just the last one... I'm still trying."

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1. Jin (斤) is a Chinese unit of weight. One jin equals 500 grams or about 1.1 pounds. So "a hundred jin" is approximately 50 kg or 110 pounds. ⇐

Chapter 175-2

After a long while, Shen Hui turned around.

Zhao Xuning reached for her hand but only caught the hem of her clothes.

Shen Hui said: "I'll do the rest."

As her words fell, her knees bent and she knelt on the stone steps.

The cold of the stone steps seeped through her knees. Shen Hui placed her hands on the stone steps, her waist gradually bending, her forehead touching the stone steps with a muffled sound.

"Second Sister." Shen Siyan walked over wanting to help her up, but heard Shen Hui say: "Don't stop me."

Shen Siyan was momentarily speechless.

Liang Shi had originally been supporting the weakened Zhao Xuning at the side.

Although she exercised regularly and was in good shape, having come all the way up from the foot of the mountain with one bow at each step, every movement perfectly standard, her legs were now trembling, feeling as if they no longer belonged to her.

How could she possibly last through these nine hundred and ninety-nine remaining stone steps?

But Zhao Xuning shook her head at her, continuing to kneel, bow, and stand up again.

Shen Hui and Zhao Xuning were only a few stone steps apart. They were both devoutly walking upward, walking forward.

With each step passed, they were forgetting.

They were atoning.

They were being reborn.

Liang Shi and Shen Siyan could only watch from behind.

It went on until nearly dawn, when cold wind rose in the mountains.

Zhao Xuning's movements grew slower and slower. It took a long time for her to kneel, then stand up again.

Her pants had already worn through.

Even Liang Shi, who had only walked up, felt tired. She simply couldn't imagine how Zhao Xuning had managed it.

And Shen Hui had truly knelt through over nine hundred steps as well.

When they were nearly at the top, they saw Shen Fenghe and Gu Yixue standing at the summit.

Shen Siyan had long been heartbroken and aggrieved. He called out softly: "Big Sister."

His voice sounded soft and childish, but he was trying hard to control this behavior and his voice, so it came out sounding awkward.

Shen Fenghe lowered her gaze to look at Shen Hui, who was still kneeling and bowing with each step. In the end, she said nothing.

Shen Hui reached the top first. When she truly stood up, her legs went weak and she nearly fell, but Shen Siyan caught her.

Zhao Xuning was obviously much slower, her entire being looking pale and haggard, as if she could faint at any moment.

Liang Shi stood right next to the railing, very close to her, afraid she wouldn't hold on and would fall.

But her willpower was truly formidable, holding on until nearly the end.

Just as she was about to take the last step, her head tilted to the side and her whole body crumpled to the ground.

The nighttime rain came without warning. After a muffled thunder, the rain began to patter down, soaking Zhao Xuning completely.

It also drenched everyone standing there.

Mother Zhao had arrived long ago and had been waiting here.

The moment she saw Zhao Xuning, she went to help her up, but Zhao Xuning pushed her away. "Leave me alone."

Mother Zhao was too heartbroken to speak.

At this moment, Zhao Xuning was curled up in the rain, like a homeless stray dog.

Liang Shi wanted to go help her, but Zhao Xuning raised her hand that hung by her side slightly, her fingers curling, signaling her not to.

Then she slowly got up in the rain, stood again, took one step forward on her two weak legs, and slowly knelt down.

She completed the final bow.

The rain grew heavier and heavier.

But Zhao Xuning had lost all sensation. Even as she lost consciousness at the end, she was smiling.

Because she had fulfilled her promise to Shen Hui.

This time, she hadn't let Shen Hui down.

Many people were calling out to her.

But she couldn't hear any of them anymore.

Zhao Xuning thought, it was right to have sworn never to climb the three thousand steps.

Because after climbing the three thousand steps, one was not far from death. Even her soul felt like it was floating.

"Zhao Xuning!"

"Ningning!"

"Dr. Zhao!"

"....."

So many voices mixed together, but Zhao Xuning still picked out Shen Hui's.

Mixed among all those voices, she was anxiously calling her name: "Zhao Xuning."

Chapter 175-3

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Zhao Xuning was truly crazy this time.

With a fever and cold, she knelt her way up the three thousand steps, and then got caught in the rain afterward.

By the time they went down the mountain, she already had a high fever and was sent directly to the hospital.

Everyone was worried sick the entire night, but she turned out to be fine. It was just that her two legs were badly damaged, her knees red, swollen, and bruised purple.

Shen Hui wasn't much better off either.

When they were sending Zhao Xuning to the hospital, she too nearly fainted from exhaustion.

However, Shen Fenghe didn't stop them this time. She directly let Shen Hui stay at the same hospital as Zhao Xuning.

They were busy rushing around until past four in the morning before it ended. When Liang Shi returned home, even though she was very quiet, she still woke Xu Qingzhu.

To be precise, Xu Qingzhu had been in a half-asleep state the whole time. When she sensed Liang Shi's return, she turned over, reached out to turn on the bedside lamp, and asked softly: "How is Dr. Zhao?"

"Nothing serious." Liang Shi slipped under the covers and reached out to hold her hand, which was still cool.

Xu Qingzhu rolled into her arms naturally. Liang Shi kissed her forehead lightly and patted her back. "Sleep peacefully."

"Mm." Xu Qingzhu yawned. In her arms, her sense of security multiplied. Drowsiness washed over her, and she quickly fell asleep.

Liang Shi turned off the bedside lamp, and the bedroom fell into darkness.

But she couldn't fall asleep no matter what.

The image of Zhao Xuning kneeling her way up the three thousand steps seemed carved into her mind.

In the past, she had acted in similar scenes.

In dramas, she had performed well enough, with enough empathy.

But it was nothing compared to today.

That was a kind of shock.

Watching Zhao Xuning's back made her heart unable to calm down. The surging emotions eventually transformed into sighs of lament.

She didn't know how much time had passed before she finally understood in her daze.

It was because Zhao Xuning was too resolute.

That kind of determination from the heart made people empathize.

Liang Shi's sympathy for Zhao Xuning increased just a little bit more.

Even though she slept late, Liang Shi didn't sleep in. She woke up naturally very early.

Xu Qingzhu had been awake for a while but stayed nestled in her arms without moving.

The moment Liang Shi opened her eyes, she saw Xu Qingzhu staring at her intently. Liang Shi was dazed for a moment, then curved her lips into a light smile, her voice low: "Good morning, baby."

"Morning~" Xu Qingzhu squinted her eyes and nuzzled further into her arms like a cat.

"Is Dr. Zhao awake yet?" Xu Qingzhu asked. "Should we go see her today~"

Liang Shi said: "I'll make some soup later and bring it to her. We'll just stay for a bit."

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "Okay."

While Liang Shi was making soup, Xu Qingzhu was also in the kitchen helping, though there wasn't really anything to do—she just wandered around the kitchen.

Xu Qingzhu asked if she couldn't sleep.

Liang Shi nodded.

"Yesterday's hot search was taken down very quickly," Xu Qingzhu said. "After that, no one discussed it anymore."

"The Zhao family had it removed," Liang Shi said. "Zhao Xuning's mother went there yesterday, and so did the Shen family. Shen Siyan really impressed me."

"Oh?" Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow.

Liang Shi recalled the scene from yesterday and briefly told her about it.

"Zhao Ling used to say Shen Siyan has a sister complex," Liang Shi smiled lightly. "Now I can see it."

"That's quite nice. I used to think families like the Shen family and the Gu family would have strict family traditions, like Dr. Zhao's family." Xu Qingzhu said. "I didn't expect them to be pretty good. They seem quite harmonious."

Liang Shi nodded: "Now those two shouldn't have to torment each other anymore."

"If they keep tormenting each other, they'll just drop dead on the spot." Xu Qingzhu shared a comment she saw yesterday. "A netizen said: I just wanted to date you, but you wanted to go to hell with me."

"Tormenting each other until their hair turns white." Liang Shi was helpless too. "I hope they can find happiness together."

"If only Dr. Zhao wasn't so reserved," Xu Qingzhu said. "She's a very direct person, but when it comes to feelings, she's not that kind of direct."

Xu Qingzhu thought for a moment before summarizing: "She's very straightforward with people she doesn't like, but becomes all awkward with people she likes."

"Right." Liang Shi said. "She also doesn't know how to communicate properly. When I was staying at her place before—something that could easily be discussed, she had to beat around the bush. She'd actually still help you with things, but her words would be unforgiving."

Xu Qingzhu hugged Liang Shi from behind. "So I still like you more."

Liang Shi's hand holding the ladle paused. "I'm not that great either."

"Then maybe I'm blind?" Xu Qingzhu's voice rose at the end.

"Well, not exactly." Liang Shi said. "Yesterday when Zhao Xuning was kneeling her way up the three thousand steps, I was thinking—if one day we ended up like that, would I do the same thing?"

Xu Qingzhu asked: "Did you come up with an answer?"

Liang Shi shook her head: "No."

Without being pushed to that point, saying whether you would or wouldn't do it would be false.

Liang Shi put the ladle down on the counter and turned to hug Xu Qingzhu: "I've decided I'll just keep loving you well. No matter how you try to push me away, I won't leave. I'll tell you everything. Then I won't need to kneel my way up three thousand steps."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

"You left secretly before though." Xu Qingzhu exposed her.

Liang Shi felt like an arrow had struck her heart and immediately explained: "I had no choice back then."

"Who in this world doesn't have moments when they have no choice?" Xu Qingzhu had thought it through clearly. "People in love separate because they have no choice—for the sake of pride, for the other person's good, sometimes wanting to escape, worldly pressure, financial pressure. Every day, people in love face different circumstances where they have no choice. But people still fall in love. Why is that?"

Liang Shi: "....."

"I can't out-argue you." Liang Shi said helplessly. "I surrender. That was indeed my mistake. I accept my punishment."

Xu Qingzhu looked up at her and bit her neck lightly. "Mm, I'll have to punish you for a long time."

"But why is that?" Liang Shi asked again. "So many people have no choice, yet they still continue to love each other. Why?"

Xu Qingzhu exhaled softly, her fingers sliding down to interlock with Liang Shi's. "Why are you with me?"

Liang Shi thought about it before answering: "Happiness. When I see you, I feel like my whole heart is filled."

That feeling of contentment was completely different from going shopping and buying things, or eating amazing food, or seeing beautiful scenery.

A heart that felt tingly and numb, warm and full.

In the twenty-four hours of a day, there was always a moment when you could feel your heart beating beautifully and passionately.

That seemed like the meaning of being alive.

Even when things outside were hard and tiring, when difficult things happened.

But just thinking that there was such a person made everything seem like nothing.

There was always motivation to keep going.

Creating bonds. Bonds bring joy.

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "So you see, people fall in love to fill their hearts."

Chapter 175-4

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Xu Qingzhu and Liang Shi went to the hospital to bring soup to Zhao Xuning. Zhao Xuning woke up briefly but fell asleep again shortly after.

The Zhao family was watching from outside.

Xu Qingzhu also went to see Shen Hui.

Shen Fenghe had gone to the company, leaving only Shen Siyan in the hospital room to keep Shen Hui company.

Xu Qingzhu chatted with Shen Hui for a while, but Shen Hui looked listless and preoccupied.

Later, Shen Siyan came in to bring fruit for them. Shen Hui asked him: "Did you find anything?"

Shen Siyan hesitated, wanting to speak but stopping himself. Finally, he made an excuse: "No."

Shen Hui frowned slightly. "What about Big Sister? She didn't find anything either?"

"No." Shen Siyan wasn't good at lying. Whenever he lied, his eyes would dart around, and his voice sounded somewhat hollow. "Anyway, you've already decided to get back together with Zhao Xuning, so just drop the investigation."

"I still need to know what happened," Shen Hui said.

She needed to know what it was that made Zhao Xuning come to her side so resolutely, so recklessly.

"Then just wait for her to wake up and tell you herself." Shen Siyan tugged at his ear and hurried away.

Xu Qingzhu sat there watching Shen Siyan and noticed that his gesture of tugging his ear just now was very similar to Liang Shi's.

When nervous, they both liked to tug at their ears.

Two fingers lightly rubbing, then hastily pulling away, looking a bit embarrassed.

Xu Qingzhu stared at Shen Siyan's retreating figure for a while, only snapping back to attention when Shen Hui called her.

Shen Hui asked quietly: "What's wrong?"

"Nothing." Xu Qingzhu shook her head.

She could always vaguely see Liang Shi's shadow in Shen Hui and her family.

It was strange.

But if she added in their previous speculations, it wasn't strange at all.

However, Shen Hui was still hospitalized now, Shen Fenghe was swamped at the company, and the Shen parents probably didn't know about any of this yet. Xu Qingzhu decided to wait until she discussed it with Liang Shi before making any decisions.

Soon, she said goodbye and returned to the company.

In the evening, Liang Shi received a call from Chen Mian.

At that time, Liang Shi had just finished filming. After a highly emotional scene, her thoughts were still somewhat scattered, and she hadn't fully gotten out of character yet.

When she answered Chen Mian's call, her voice still had a tearful quality. Chen Mian paused briefly: "What's going on?"

"Ah... nothing." Liang Shi's tone was somewhat slow. "What did you need me for?"

There was the sound of pages turning on Chen Mian's end, then it went quiet: "Do you know Qiu Zimin?"

Liang Shi: "....."

"I do." Liang Shi asked: "What about it?"

Chen Mian said: "She's offering fifty million to buy a piece in my collection."

"Uh." Liang Shi was slow to react, not knowing what this had to do with her.

Chen Mian continued: "This painting was done by a woman named Shen Chi. It depicts three women boating on a lake—Shen Chi, Zhu Mingqi, and Qiu Zimin. Their names are written in small text on the painting."

Liang Shi frowned slightly. She finally emerged somewhat from her earlier intense emotions, and her mind started working: "And then? Zhu Mingqi and Qiu Zimin know each other?"

"They should." Chen Mian said: "If I remember correctly, Zhu Mingqi also once wanted to buy my paintings, saying my work was about fifty percent similar to that of an old acquaintance."

Liang Shi: "....."

"So that would be Shen Chi?" Liang Shi asked.

Chen Mian responded with a "mm." "I was trained in Shen Chi's lineage."

"So what does all this... have to do with me?" Liang Shi asked again.

She still couldn't figure it out.

"Or would you like to see this painting?" Chen Mian didn't say directly but went in a roundabout way.

Liang Shi didn't understand her intention but agreed anyway. "Then send it over."

Soon, Chen Mian hung up and sent her a photo.

Liang Shi looked at it and thought it was well painted. Also, the Qiu Zimin in the painting was much prettier than she was now. Zhu Mingqi looked familiar—probably because she had seen her at the art museum before.

She specifically zoomed in to look, then relayed her observations to Chen Mian.

After listening, Chen Mian went silent for a while.

Liang Shi: [What's wrong? Am I mistaken?]

Chen Mian: [Forget it, I won't make it difficult for you.]

Liang Shi: [.....]

After a while, Chen Mian sent her a voice message: "Because you probably look at things on the surface, but we painters look at bone structure. Haven't you noticed that Zhu Mingqi's bone structure is about seventy percent similar to yours? When I first saw it, I thought it was you."

Liang Shi: "?"

Chen Mian sent another message: "But that's just my guess, can't take it as fact. However, after I put out news about this painting, both Zhu Mingqi and Qiu Zimin came to me wanting to buy it. Zhu Mingqi offered ten million, and Qiu Zimin offered fifty million."

Liang Shi: "...You're really rich."

Chen Mian: "?"

Liang Shi stared at the painting again and again but still didn't think the resemblance was that strong.

Maybe it was because she was too used to looking at herself.

However...

Liang Shi asked Chen Mian: "So what's the relationship between Zhu Mingqi and Qiu Zimin?"

Chen Mian answered very straightforwardly: "Love rivals."

"Shen Chi had countless romantic rumors when she was young." Chen Mian said: "But she had two childhood sweethearts—one was her white moonlight, one was her cinnabar mole."¹

Liang Shi: "?"

You artists really have quite the romantic histories.

1. "White moonlight" (白月光) and "cinnabar mole" (朱砂痣) are Chinese literary terms for different types of unforgettable loves. "White moonlight" refers to a pure, idealized first love that one can never forget—someone unattainable and perfect in memory. "Cinnabar mole" refers to a love that leaves an indelible mark on one's heart, like a red mole that can never be erased. The terms come from a famous essay by Zhang Ailing (Eileen Chang), where she wrote that every man has two such women in his life. In modern usage, they represent two types of unforgettable past loves. ⇐